

THE HINDU | MAY 27, 2026

Editorial Analysis

Comprehensive Study Guide, Vocabulary Builder & RC

Bad fences

Marco Rubio's visit was an opportunity to mend economic and energy ties

Secretary of State Marco Rubio's four-day visit to India, his first since taking office in January 2025, was understood to have been aimed at smoothing **bilateral** ties that have been deeply **ruptured** over the past year. The problems have been **multifold**, ranging from the U.S.'s high tariffs and cutting down on visas, immigration and outsourcing; to sanctions on India's energy **procurement** and investment, its moves with China and Pakistan, and the **pejorative** remarks by President Donald Trump and his cabinet colleagues about India. Although the Modi government has not criticised the U.S. for its actions, there is no doubt that the U.S. attack on Iran on February 28, the wider regional conflict and the Hormuz Strait blockade, have caused immense economic worries for India as well. It was thus hoped that Mr. Rubio's visit, which combined the bilateral agenda alongside the Quad Foreign Ministers' meeting, would help repair one of the worst phases in bilateral ties caused largely by Washington's **unilateral** moves. Mr. Rubio consistently held that the relationship was well and that "President Trump loves India", while responding to repeated questions on Mr. Trump's post that **amplified** anti-immigrant **sentiments** referring to India as a "hell-hole". New Delhi had no doubt laid out the red carpet for Mr. Rubio. In a departure from protocol, Prime Minister Narendra Modi welcomed him on his arrival and External

Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar spent much of the weekend in meetings with Mr. Rubio, including two U.S. Embassy receptions. On Sunday, Mr. Jaishankar attended a celebration marking the U.S.'s 250th Independence Day and Mr. Rubio's birthday. Mr. Rubio visited the Missionaries of Charity, in Kolkata, and went to Agra and Jaipur for sightseeing. In bilateral talks, the Foreign Ministers discussed the full **gamut** of ties, including trade, energy, civil nuclear technological and defence cooperation, as well as the regional and **geopolitical** conflicts.

However, apart from one agreement on **critical** minerals cooperation, which **replicates** their partnership within the Quad and the 15-nation Pax Silica, the visit's bilateral part ended with few outcomes of note. Mr. Rubio's refusal to **acknowledge** a problem in the relationship indicates that the U.S., once considered India's most trusted partnership, has failed to recognise New Delhi's concerns. It is hoped, however, that Mr. Rubio was **informed** of them, as both sides prepare for a possible Modi-Trump meeting at the G-7 Summit in Evian, France, in mid-June, where India is a special invitee. This will be the first time that the leaders have come face to face since Mr. Modi's February 2025 Washington visit and all that followed, and an opportunity to mend the relationship especially in the areas it has **frayed** the most – economic, energy and regional security.

1. Article Summary

The editorial analyzes US Secretary of State Marco Rubio's recent visit to India, intended to repair a relationship deeply strained by US tariffs, visa restrictions, energy sanctions, and derogatory rhetoric from the Trump administration. Despite India's warm reception and extensive discussions on a full gamut of bilateral and geopolitical issues, the visit yielded minimal concrete results, notably just one agreement on critical minerals. The author suggests that Rubio's refusal to acknowledge these underlying issues reflects a US failure to address New Delhi's concerns, though hope remains that the upcoming G-7 summit will provide a real opportunity for Prime Minister Modi and President Trump to substantively mend economic and regional security ties.



ANATOMY OF STRAINED BILATERAL TIES

The factors contributing to the diplomatic friction discussed in the editorial



Economic Fences

High tariffs, visa cuts, and sanctions on energy procurement.



Hostile Rhetoric

Amplified anti-immigrant sentiments and pejorative remarks.



The Hope Ahead

Mending ties at the G-7 Summit through direct, face-to-face dialogue.

2. Important Vocabulary Analysis (15 Words)

Word & POS	Meaning (Hindi & Eng)	Synonyms (5)	Antonyms (5)
Bilateral (Adj)	द्विपक्षीय Involving two parties, especially countries.	Mutual, Reciprocal, Joint, Dual, Two-sided	Unilateral, Multilateral, Independent, One-sided, Single
Ruptured (Verb/Adj)	टूटा हुआ / खंडित Broken, breached, or severed.	Severed, Broken, Damaged, Fractured, Split	Mended, Restored, Healed, Joined, United
Multifold (Adj)	बहुआयामी Many times as great or as much; numerous.	Numerous, Many, Various, Manifold, Varied	Single, Few, Minimal, Limited, Sparse
Procurement (Noun)	प्राप्ति / खरीद The action of obtaining or purchasing equipment or supplies.	Acquisition, Purchasing, Gathering, Obtaining, Securing	Disposal, Sale, Loss, Relinquishment, Surrender

Word & POS	Meaning (Hindi & Eng)	Synonyms (5)	Antonyms (5)
Pejorative (Adj)	अपमानजनक Expressing contempt or disapproval.	Derogatory, Belittling, Insulting, Offensive, Critical	Complimentary, Laudatory, Praising, Respectful, Positive
Unilateral (Adj)	एकतरफा Action performed by one person or country without others' agreement.	One-sided, Independent, Solo, Single, Autonomous	Bilateral, Multilateral, Joint, Collaborative, Shared
Amplified (Verb)	बढ़ाया हुआ Increased the volume or intensity of something.	Magnified, Intensified, Boosted, Exaggerated, Expanded	Reduced, Decreased, Muffled, Minimized, Lessened
Sentiments (Noun)	भावनाएं A feeling, emotion, or widespread opinion.	Feelings, Emotions, Attitudes, Opinions, Beliefs	Apathy, Indifference, Facts, Logic, Reason
Gamut (Noun)	विस्तार / दायरा The complete range or scope of something.	Spectrum, Range, Scope, Extent, Scale	Fraction, Part, Segment, Limitation, Piece
Geopolitical (Adj)	भू-राजनीतिक Relating to politics, especially international relations influenced by geography.	Strategic, Territorial, Global, Political, International	Local, Domestic, Non-strategic, Isolated, Internal
Critical (Adj)	महत्वपूर्ण Of decisive importance with respect to the success or failure of something.	Crucial, Essential, Vital, Pivotal, Important	Trivial, Unimportant, Minor, Insignificant, Negligible
Replicates (Verb)	नकल करना / दोहराना Make an exact copy of; reproduce.	Duplicates, Copies, Reproduces, Mimics, Mirrors	Originates, Creates, Invents, Destroys, Innovates
Acknowledge (Verb)	स्वीकार करना Accept or admit the existence or truth of.	Admit, Recognize, Concede, Accept, Confess	Deny, Ignore, Reject, Disregard, Refuse
Informed (Verb/Adj)	सूचित करना / जानकार Having or showing knowledge of a subject or situation.	Apprised, Notified, Educated, Aware, Advised	Ignorant, Unaware, Clueless, Blind, Unenlightened
Frayed (Adj)	घिसा हुआ / तनावपूर्ण Showing the effects of strain (about a person's nerves, temper, or a relationship).	Strained, Tense, Worn, Exhausted, Stressed	Intact, Calm, Relaxed, Strong, Mended

3. Idioms, Phrases & Parts of Speech

Idioms & Phrases used in the Editorial:

- **Lay out the red carpet:** To give a special, formal, or very welcoming treatment to a guest. (Ex: *New Delhi had no doubt laid out the red carpet for Mr. Rubio.*)
- **A departure from protocol:** Doing something in a way that breaks standard formal rules or established traditions to show special attention. (Ex: *In a departure from protocol, Prime Minister Narendra Modi welcomed him on his arrival.*)
- **Face to face:** In direct physical presence of each other. (Ex: *This will be the first time that the leaders have come face to face since Mr. Modi's February 2025 Washington visit.*)

Crucial Parts of Speech Identified:

- **Nouns:** Procurement, Sentiments, Gamut, Blockade, Receptions.
- **Verbs:** Ruptured, Amplified, Replicates, Acknowledge, Frayed.
- **Adjectives:** Bilateral, Multifold, Pejorative, Unilateral, Critical.
- **Adverbs:** Deeply, Consistently, Largely, Especially, Ultimately.
- **Prepositions:** Against, Throughout, Beyond, Within.

■ **Educational Note:** The term "*Bilateral*" (Bi = two, Lateral = sides) refers to agreements or ties between exactly two parties. When multiple nations are involved, it is called "*Multilateral*" (e.g., the Quad).

4. Practice Questions

A. Fill in the Blanks (Choose the correct Synonym)

1. The visit was aimed at smoothing _____ ties that had been deeply damaged.
(A) Mutual
(B) Unilateral
(C) Conflicting
(D) Isolated
(E) Disconnected
2. Ties have been deeply _____ over the past year due to several diplomatic missteps.
(A) Mended
(B) Severed
(C) Bolstered
(D) Sustained
(E) Overlooked
3. The President's cabinet made extremely _____ remarks about the developing nation.
(A) Complimentary
(B) Derogatory
(C) Praising
(D) Neutral
(E) Encouraging
4. The major economic problem was caused by Washington's sudden and _____ moves in the trade sector.
(A) Multilateral
(B) One-sided
(C) Cooperative
(D) Shared
(E) Bipartisan
5. During the meetings, the foreign ministers discussed the full _____ of geopolitical issues.
(A) Spectrum
(B) Limitation
(C) Portion
(D) Scarcity
(E) Absence

Answers: 1. (A) Mutual [Synonym for Bilateral] | 2. (B) Severed [Synonym for Ruptured] | 3. (B) Derogatory [Synonym for Pejorative] | 4. (B) One-sided [Synonym for Unilateral] | 5. (A) Spectrum [Synonym for Gamut]

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B. Error Detection

1. (A) Secretary of State Marco Rubio's / (B) four-day visit to India / (C) were understood to have been / (D) aimed at smoothing bilateral ties. / (E) No Error.
2. (A) The problems have been multifold, / (B) ranging from the U.S.'s high tariffs / (C) and cutting down on visas, / (D) immigration and outsourcing. / (E) No Error.
3. (A) It was thus hope that / (B) Mr. Rubio's visit would / (C) help repair one of the worst / (D) phases in bilateral ties. / (E) No Error.
4. (A) Mr. Rubio consistently held / (B) that the relationship was well / (C) and that President Trump / (D) love India. / (E) No Error.
5. (A) This will be the first time / (B) that the leaders has come / (C) face to face since Mr. Modi's / (D) February 2025 Washington visit. / (E) No Error.

Answers:

1. (C) were → was (The subject 'visit' is singular, hence it takes the singular verb 'was').
2. (E) No Error (The sentence is grammatically correct).
3. (A) hope → hoped (Passive voice structure 'It was + V3' is required here).
4. (D) love → loves (Singular subject 'President Trump' requires the singular verb 'loves').
5. (B) has → have (Plural subject 'leaders' requires the plural verb 'have').

5. Reading Comprehension

Read the following passage carefully and answer the questions:

Secretary of State Marco Rubio's four-day visit to India, his first since taking office in January 2025, was understood to have been aimed at smoothing bilateral ties that have been deeply ruptured over the past year. The problems have been multifold, ranging from the U.S.'s high tariffs and cutting down on visas, immigration and outsourcing; to sanctions on India's energy procurement and investment, its moves with China and Pakistan, and the pejorative remarks by President Donald Trump and his cabinet colleagues about India. Although the Modi government has not criticised the U.S. for its actions, there is no doubt that the U.S. attack on Iran on February 28, the wider regional conflict and the Hormuz Strait blockade, have caused immense economic worries for India as well. However, apart from one agreement on critical minerals cooperation, which replicates their partnership within the Quad and the 15-nation Pax Silica, the visit's bilateral part ended with few

outcomes of note. Mr. Rubio's refusal to acknowledge a problem in the relationship indicates that the U.S., once considered India's most trusted partnership, has failed to recognise New Delhi's concerns.

1. What was the primary objective of Marco Rubio's four-day visit to India?
 - (A) To initiate a new military alliance against neighboring hostile states.
 - (B) To smooth over deeply ruptured bilateral relations from the past year.
 - (C) To formally apologize for the pejorative remarks made by the US administration.
 - (D) To negotiate a direct peace treaty regarding the Hormuz Strait blockade.
 - (E) To declare economic sanctions against India's energy procurement sector.
2. Which of the following is NOT mentioned as a reason for the ruptured ties between the US and India?
 - (A) The US imposing high tariffs and cutting down on visas and immigration.
 - (B) Sanctions placed on India's energy procurement and associated investments.
 - (C) India's explicit and harsh public criticism of the US government's recent actions.
 - (D) The US military attack on Iran and the resulting wider regional conflict.
 - (E) Derogatory remarks made by the US President and his cabinet colleagues.
3. What does the author imply about Mr. Rubio's refusal to acknowledge problems in the relationship?
 - (A) It demonstrates the US's unyielding dominance in global trade negotiations.
 - (B) It proves that all prior bilateral disputes were entirely fabricated by the media.
 - (C) It suggests that the US has failed to genuinely recognize New Delhi's valid concerns.
 - (D) It indicates that India has secretly accepted all of the unilateral US demands.
 - (E) It guarantees a highly successful and tension-free upcoming G-7 summit meeting.
4. What was the only major outcome of the bilateral talks during the visit?
 - (A) A comprehensive trade and defense cooperation treaty across the Indo-Pacific.
 - (B) An agreement focusing exclusively on civil nuclear technology and software outsourcing.
 - (C) A resolution to immediately end the Hormuz Strait blockade by deploying joint naval fleets.
 - (D) A single agreement centered specifically on critical minerals cooperation.
 - (E) A definitive pact to halt all current and future outsourcing sanctions permanently.
5. Why has the U.S. attack on Iran caused immense worries for India?
 - (A) Because India relies heavily on exporting weapons directly to Iran's military.
 - (B) Because the resulting regional conflict and Hormuz Strait blockade threaten economic stability.
 - (C) Because it forces India to permanently close all its embassies in the Middle East.
 - (D) Because the attack directly targeted Indian citizens residing in the Iranian capital.
 - (E) Because India was blamed globally for providing the intelligence used in the attack.

RC Answers: 1. (B) | 2. (C) | 3. (C) | 4. (D) | 5. (B)

"An investment in knowledge pays the best interest."

– Benjamin Franklin

"The mind is not a vessel to be filled, but a fire to be kindled."

– Plutarch

 ***Wishing you a wonderful season of growth and learning! Thank you for dedicating your time to understanding the world around you. Every effort you put in today builds the foundation for tomorrow's success. 🌟***

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